

PREPARATORY ACTIVITY WATCH

Ukraine: Preparatory Activity Watch

5-8 April 2021 | Information available by 23:59Z, 8 April | replay

Analytic state: Watch | AnCR: Moderate | Change: Broadening multi-domain anomaly

Keys: Russia; Ukraine; Moscow; Ukrainian border; Yelnya; Klinty; Belgorod; Valuyki; Boguchar; Millerovo; Dzhankoi

Assessment

We assess it is almost certain that abnormal activity is present across several Russian observables with bearing on Ukraine.

Russian financial conditions, public reporting on Russia and Ukraine and physical activity are simultaneously elevated relative to their recent baselines. The signal is co-movement across those channels.

It is a realistic possibility that this reflects reversible preparation, defensive readiness, routine variation or exercise activity. Present reporting does not discriminate among those explanations.

The decision this supports is collection against independent physical posture on those AOIs.

Why this is on the watchlist

Indicator	Observation	Analytic significance
Russian financial conditions	USD/RUB reached 2.56 sigma on 6 Apr (last print 76.86)	Large deviation from the recent baseline.
Public reporting	GDELT reporting remained elevated; Wikipedia attention rose from 19,535 to 20,284 views	Confirms a heightened information environment; partly dependent on the same public reporting.
Physical activity	FIRMS recorded 10 thermal detections within the monitored staging AOIs on 5 Apr, 6 Apr, 8 Apr.	Large deviation from the recent baseline.
Maritime warnings	NAVAREA warnings declined from 23 to 10	Does not reinforce the broader anomaly.

GDELT, ICEWS and Wikipedia share a public-reporting substrate.

Competing explanations

Likelihoods use the PHIA Probability Yardstick.

Hypothesis	Likelihood	What would discriminate
Routine variation	Realistic possibility	Anomalies decay without additional domains activating.
Exercise / demonstration	Realistic possibility	Physical activity consistent with announced exercise patterns.
Defensive readiness	Realistic possibility	Persistent posture indicators without further domain broadening.
Reversible preparation	Realistic possibility	Additional independent logistical, financial or spatial indicators.
Preparation for overt action	Realistic possibility	Sustained multi-domain increase plus corroborating physical or official-posture evidence.
Measurement artefact	Unlikely	Anomalies disappear after source or baseline validation.

Collection requirements

1. Official posture. Collect contemporaneous Russian, Ukrainian, UK, US and relevant allied official statements and formal measures, including travel advice, diplomatic drawdowns, defence announcements, NOTAM/NAVAREA restrictions and sanctions measures. Identify changes in declared threat assessment or costly government action.

2. Information-environment composition. Current data establish increased volume and attention, not tone, narrative concentration or source diversity.

Analyst note

Analytical confidence is moderate. The information base is incomplete: official-posture collection is missing; public-reporting series share a substrate. The key uncertainty is whether the cross-domain anomaly is a temporary response to the existing crisis environment or the early observable consequences of material preparation.